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Endangered species? An interview with Jean Baudrillard

Paul Sutton [a]
[a] Doctoral student in the Department of Modem Languages, University of Bradford,

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paul sutton

ENDANGERED SPECIES?

an interview with jean baudrillard[1]

In 1994 Baudrillard published a pamphlet in France entitled *La pensée radicale*, in which he proclaims:

> The absolute rule of thought is: render the world as it was given to us – unintelligible – and if possible, a little more unintelligible. A little more enigmatic.

In the interview that follows (conducted in December 1994),[2] the ironic "(anti-)manifesto" of *La pensée radicale* is discernible in Baudrillard's discussion of thought and language. The interview coincided with a visit to the UK to publicize the English translation of *L'échange symbolique et la mort* and took place two days after Baudrillard delivered a paper at the Institute of Contemporary Arts in London. Thus whilst there is no specific agenda, the interview does address both *Symbolic Exchange and Death* and the ICA paper, which although untitled was introduced by Baudrillard as a "talk about virtual illusion or ... the automatic writing of the world." This lack of an agenda was based on a conscious decision not to impose a structure but to allow Baudrillard to talk as freely as possible; questions were asked simply as catalysts to thought and speech rather than as demands for detailed response. It was felt that in interviews where Baudrillard was subjected to insistent questioning, the results were unproductive; it seemed preferable, therefore, to allow Baudrillard the freedom to speak more as he writes, in other words, without limit...

The first question concerns what you said at the ICA. You were asked if you used a computer; amusing, but interesting also, because you spoke in your talk of "automatic writing" and I wanted to know exactly what that might be and how it relates to the computer.

J.B.: Yes, it's virtuality, well, automatic writing – obviously it has nothing to do with the Surrealists; I'm not thinking of this kind of automatism of the unconscious. No, here it is the fact that the world writes itself, that it no longer exists; that the world in its presence exists only as directly coded, encoded and decoded, that it is only a matter of the substance of the code, of numeration, of accounting [*comptabilitisation*]. Inscription would be the true term really, automatic sounds better but it's more inscription, a kind of obligatory inscription; after all everything is in inscription, in the network, and at that moment human presence, human intervention, becomes more and more superfluous, more and more pointless. Up to a certain point machines become self-referential and the world itself, well, the processes become self-referential; it functions alone and in a certain way we are in another interspace – we don't know where exactly, we are no longer actors really, we are machine operators and, as such,

we ourselves are kinds of automata. But this is not a scornful vision of automatism; it is, however, very different from the mechanical machine, that of the nineteenth century, the industrial machine – with that there is still a relationship, even if conflictual, between man and machine; there are other things, there is alienation, but there is still a duality, man/machine; even if the machine is fetishized, man exists, there is a subject and an object, whereas in automatization there is ultimately a kind of superfusion of the two – there is no longer this opposition here. The automaton is something else; where there is no longer a subject, nothing more than a kind of object in a closed circuit, in short circuit and therefore the relationship is no longer the same. It is equivalent to a kind of enormous celibate machine. Mechanical machines, though, were still machines with an alterity, an other, whereas here it is a huge celibate machine, completely self-referential, and at this point one wonders where the real world is... This kind of artificial world, much more performative than ever before, completely automatized, is also an exclusion in the end, an exclusion of man, of the real world, of all referentiality. But the term writing, well it's really only the fact that virtuality passes through kinds of languages, numerical inscriptions, syntheses, etc. Automatic writing also interests me because of the fact that in this inscription of the world nothing can take place without having happened in its duplicate inscription. There is no simple, original or historic event really – it always happens in the virtual – it is equivalent to a kind of code of automatic disappearance from the world.

On a personal level, when it comes to writing, do you find that one is too close when using a computer, that one lacks a certain distance?

J.B.: Yes, well we spoke about the fact that for me the computer is effectively... one is in a kind of "real time" of writing and I don't believe in writing in "real time"; I think that basically the computer produces a certain sort of text. I see friends who work with their computers and, I don't know, it produces a form of thinking I suppose, a sort of loop writing (*écriture en boucles*) which functions well [effectively], but which is like a program really, a kind of programming, processing; but, for me, I see writing, theory, as absolute deferral. The distance between language and the idea or between ideas and the event is necessary. There mustn't be collusion, or collision – same thing really – between the text and, well, without exaggerating this kind of confusion, between the text and the image. In other words one is entering a world where, in my opinion, the text has come into existence via the image. This leads to a lot of aesthetic performances – they have already taken place with Godard in the cinema – where the text is already also the image. It's interesting, but in terms of theory and analysis it's not possible because there one must maintain the text as text and one must really reduce mediatization, the technical medium really, as much as possible; and in the case of the computer, a technical medium that is extremely transparent, not authoritarian, that isn't, that doesn't seem particularly manipulative – it's not like television, etc. – in actual fact it is, in my opinion, very self-sufficient, it's the computer that works in fact...

It's the computer, then, that drives thought?

J.B.: Yes... in the end thought only functions when solicited by the machine or in response to questions posed by the machine itself, well by the machinic [*machinal*] logic of something like a computer. The old machines, *la mécanicité*, are not dangerous, they are alienating and correspond to a certain history, whereas *la machinalité* – I'll try and explain the difference, I don't know

if it can be done in English – so, *mécanicité* is the archaeology almost of the machine and *la machinalité* is a kind of automaticity [*l'automaticité*], it's something completely different and can be very positive. For example I think that Andy Warhol works on the image within the *machinalité* of the image, he wanted to be a machine, a serial machine, an automatic [*machinal*] machine; so it can be positive. However in the operation of thought, to say that one cannot be, for thought, for theory, that one cannot be an operator, is not possible because with these machines one increasingly becomes an operator, so that one can do many more things. I think that it opens in fact all the mechanized possibilities, but one must not call on all of one's resources, one must never call on all one's resources. On a computer one can do anything with a text – correct it, transform it, combine it, paste it – and I feel that it's almost, if you want, the height of liberty, it's the result, the disappearance of a certain liberty, but a liberty that has no more meaning because it is simply combinatory [*combinatoire*], a sort of immense combinative liberty, but I think that for thought it's something else...

It's a problem of excess..?

J.B.: Yes, excess.

What about books themselves, as actual objects, given technology such as the CD-ROM, etc?

J.B.: Well, I'm protected by the fact that I don't really have much to do with those kinds of things – it's only a taperecorder really... I don't even know how to use one, unless someone uses it for me, but, well I don't really have a use for one. But it's not a case of an ideological or moral refusal, you know... books, well that's still something, an object... but here it's not from nostalgia you know... There is a form, a rhythm in a book, you see, a kind of mental space; there is a rhythm and a physicality to the book and also a kind of metaphysicality, but difficult to express. I'm defending the book and becoming immediately anachronistic. There isn't a problem, I'm not superstitious about books or about reading, in fact I'm not an immoderate reader. Well a book is something that one can grasp, but I don't have a library and I'm not a lover of books either. A book is a mental structure [*organisation*] and there are others... one could propose a mental structure that no longer depended on writing which could be very good, it could be a culture – there are cultures without writing – but that's something else; we are a culture with writing. It is true that we have maintained a discursive structure of the mind which has marked us, however whether we could, in reality, move to a nondiscursive structure which would be, which would set itself up differently because there it would be of the signal, the combinatory, etc... Yes, certainly one day, one day everyone will go this way I believe. Me, I might be an endangered species perhaps [*laughs*], well that's a choice to be made...

In L'échange symbolique et la mort, *it seems to me that you were suggesting that the ultimate resistance to the digital code was death. Are you searching for a position of symbolic death in relation to the proliferation of codes surrounding your work? As you have pushed various discourses, like Marxism, for example, to a point of collapse, are you and have you always performed this process with your work? Is this a suicidal strategy?*

J.B.: [*laughs*] Yes, it's kind of that, it's the idea of taking death to the heart of concepts or a system, where a system by definition does not carry its own death but attempts to perpetuate itself through a kind of infinite regeneration; so one must push it to the

limit, evidently, where it will break down. One must take death to it, that does not mean necessarily to destroy it, it means to effectively inoculate something like the void, nothingness, death, into the heart of a system where there is none remaining. I take nothingness to the heart of the image, reinstall the void at the heart of the image. Of course everything must not be full of meaning and this seems to me to be the most vital operation if I can say (it must be said), because when one enters into the order of unilateral production, everything is produced, everything therefore appears as positive – okay, there is negativity but after all one is looking for everything to become positive, absolute in the world, to become subject, to become positive. This symbolic exchange between appearing and disappearing is the complete symbolic operation, everything that appears disappears, everything that disappears can reappear – here there is a symbolic exchange. In production there is nothing finally but the moment of apparition, there is no longer disappearance and thus we are no longer in a situation of reversibility. Disappearance in this sense is not extermination of course; death, disappearance is no longer here, so I believe that the work of thinking is rather like this in a way, not at all fatal [*mortifère*], it isn't an instant death, it's not that at all; it's to restore to power a kind of negativity, a symbolic form of death, a type of reversibility, to regain everything in reverse, and it is very much that that I have tried to do with ideas or with concepts like Marxism, etc.

But to go to the end of processes in order to let them disappear... the opportunity to disappear is as important as the chance to appear, anyway it is equivalent in a way to disappearance, the equivalent of the chance to appear and in fact only that which has appeared can disappear; when one can no longer disappear in any way, one no longer exists; I mean that one is in a complete afterlife but one is no longer in life. It is true that our culture – modern, technical – tries to split the positive moment from the negative moment and to conserve only the positive and so one ends up in a kind of ultrareal reality, a hyperreality which has no end; our culture no longer contains its end – this is the problematic of *L'illusion de la fin ou la grève des événements*. That's to say that things no longer have the potential themselves for their own death, they can no longer control their own death, and that was the actual story of historical extermination in the concentration camps. The people who arrived there were not able to control their own deaths, they weren't even given the opportunity to die, they were already dead – that's extermination. One must rediscover death in a way beyond extermination or against extermination.

The word death is always open to misinterpretation but one is forced to use such words if there aren't any others. Death here becomes a total paradigm, but it can be negativity – it can be all sorts of things – in another sense it can be the feminine, it can be, well... it's a landmark word, symbolic, and the problem is that one cannot rewrite, uncover all its definitions. It's an ambiguous word in a way, it carries this vast symbolic potential and the danger even of the definitive end. It seems to me that all the enterprises of a system are to put an end to death. It is a paradox but one that is true. We are not there, but we must watch where we are going...

I'm very interested in the style of your writing – an almost excessive style, melodramatic, a hyperbolic style. Your writing seems to mirror your strategy...

J.B.: Oh yes, I agree completely. I don't think that one can really, seriously, rigorously separate an idea from its meaning, in the way in

which it is said or written. It seems impossible to me really and it is for this that I reproach writings, philosophies, etc. It is as if one wasn't taking the act of writing into account; in the end it's a medium, a way to transcribe something that might have a written meaning. Writing is a basic sense, it's a style but not really a manner – I mean that it's not a mannerism. However it is, at this point, a kind of poetic idea – the idea only exists once embodied and that to me seems an impoverishment. My texts are always strictly about ideas and at this point it's a nihilism of this or that, it's pessimistic, demoralising, despairing and it is never a question of the happiness of writing [*bonheur de l'écriture*]. It seems to me that writing, if one can attain it, is the happy resolution [*la résolution heureuse*] of the unhappiness of meaning [*malheur du sens*], because criticism is always unhappy by definition, whereas language is happy, you know, even when it speaks of the most desperate things – the expression can be happy and therefore still a resolution through the materiality of language and through the ambiguity of meaning or by the blockages wherein ideas are always insoluble. One will never solve the world using an ideate formula [*une formule idéeique*], by an idea; language on the other hand is, I think, a resolution, not a solution. Thought [*la pensée*] searching for absolution, a full stop, is in a way absurd. Language does not look for a solution, there are no solutions in language but there is a resolution, as in Saussure's anagrams. As for language or political language, that is the total resolution of all the elements of language that are used up. Nothing is left; the ideal situation which creates a kind of event, which is not at all an explanation of the world – evidently one can't exactly explain the world by a thought – but it is thought made world [*la pensée faite monde*]. At this point thought, the thought of language and mind [*la pensée*], becomes a sort of pure object, a pure event. It is more difficult to work with that than with a language that only wants to communicate, to transmit something. There is a kind of crime here against thought, a kind of total contempt for the very fact of writing. Someone like Barthes has clearly revealed this, he has really spoken properly of writing [*écriture*] – he seems to say: listen, you, you think; me, I write. It's an act that one cannot forget, efface.

Thus it seems to me that in the use of a computer, word processor, writing as writing, as act, is obliterated. There is a kind of "acting out" of writing, a kind of "mind processing" – language is there to maintain the distance between things in order that everything is not in total confusion. So these languages exist often so that everything does not signify. Language is not just for saying anything, it's to make sure that, on the one hand, everything doesn't have the same meaning and, on the other, to make sure that things keep their distance – I don't know really if the mind keeps its distance from the world, I mean to say that language creates this distance towards the world and gives, ultimately, this impression [*effet*] of the real. Without distance, if one is the "live" operator [*opérateur direct*] of the world in "real time," there is no longer a need for language, it becomes a useless function, as useless as sexuality for clones; clones once they have been cloned no longer need to be sexualized, no longer need sex. So we are moving slowly towards the automatic disappearance of symbolic functions...

It's more a question of a kind of information rather than the possibility of communication?

J.B.: Yes, that's it. It's all a problem of communication. Communication is no more than a sort of binary mechanism [*dispositif*] with a coder, decoder and mediator [*médium*] –

well, all the functions. It must be said that semiology, semiotics, etc. has in truth rendered us a great service and yet it was also extremely dangerous. There is a language of communication that can be analysed, decoded, deciphered, but the danger is to take all language for a language of communication – there is also something else in play/at stake [*en jeu*][3] and it's an important stake because I don't believe in the magic of language, I am not a prophetic poet or anything, but in my opinion I have the impression that ideas in themselves, that is the reflexive, critical content of thought, have less and less influence in actual fact on the world, they don't in the end change much in the world. I feel that a single event of pure language is more important – not directly, it has no direct consequences, one cannot see what it becomes, what one does with it – but that existence at a given moment, through a powerful act of language, through a struggle to produce style, to give form to something, has in the long, or perhaps medium term, more importance.

So for me, the books that I write alternate between the two; there is, however, a kind of will to communicate meaning despite everything and besides it's true that there is a form of attraction, hyperbolic as you say, towards something other, which is of the order of seduction. There is a production of ideas nonetheless but seduction, seduction can only come from language...

In La transparence du Mal: Essai sur les phénomènes extrêmes, *you talk about transaesthetics, transpolitics, transsexuality, etc. What exactly do you mean by this notion of* trans? *Does it relate to this notion of...*

J.B.: No, it's not exactly transgression in the sense of Bataille, it isn't a question of prohibition/transgression; it's hard to say whether one should take a particle like "post-" or "trans-" or "meta-," wherein one sees all sorts of possibilities like that... *trans*, transpolitics, transeconomics... we were just saying that the economic and political processes have gone beyond their end, their finality. Transpolitics is politics from the moment when everything is political and when nothing is really political because there are no longer any real definitions – one is in the transpolitical and at this point anything that happens is no longer political and happens in opposition to the political; thus for me this completely changes the direction of things because events, even social events, etc. that are no longer interesting, happen now almost against history, against politics, whereas before they took place in the direction of history or in the direction of politics and things changed their meaning completely according to the same events, changed meaning according to what took place in an ascendant history in the making or in a history in the unmaking which could no longer speak; now the transpolitical is rather like history in the unmaking, because it is already beyond its own ending... This is the paradoxical situation moreover, incomprehensible in a way, we are already beyond our own end understood in the sense of finality. Production at least gave itself to a social purpose [*finalité*], historical etc.; but here, given the machinery of production, the kind of megalomania of production, excess really, but an excess completely beyond excess, production has lost its purpose, it has passed to the other side. We are no longer on this side of the end, in other words the possibility of future, utopia, etc. We have already gone past this moment and suddenly there is no more utopia, etc. because everything is already behind us, and this could be the transpolitical, and one could say the same for economics, for political economy in the traditional sense with laws of equivalence, the market; all that. It still exists but it is no longer that which is determinant; above it there is a kind of space of

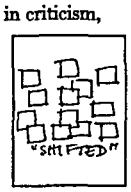
speculation, a speculation zone, a pure circulation that is transeconomics; economics is no longer guided by rationality... we are in something else, in processes that are much more turbulent, uncertain, chaotic perhaps – it is here that we can also find chaos theory...

For the transsexual it is effectively the obliteration of sexual difference, the potential polarization of sexuality into something that is neither exactly masculine or feminine, or that is perhaps no longer exactly sexed, and where this sexual division of things is, at the end of the day, no longer measurable. It's not a case of going beyond the end of reproduction – sexuality already exists, it's been around for a long time, without exactly being a perversion – but the principle of sexualization [*sexuation*], the principle of differentiation, is – here also – exceeded in a kind of automatic practice of sexuality, an automatic writing of sex, or something like that... with all the extra meanings that pornography (these overwhelming scenes of sexuality) and all these things bring, where sexuality... or desire at any rate, is effaced by its own excess, by its demonstration, its "*mise en scène.*"

So there we have the *trans;* that's what it means really. To simplify *trans*, it's that which has gone beyond its own end – perhaps it's more the transfinitive – it's a term that exists in, I don't know if it's physics or mathematics... the transfinitive, beyond the end, and there I think that it creates a universe where the laws, if you want and the rules of causality and finality, are all perverted; ultimately it's a vertigo of exchange... The curvatures are different, we are certainly in a different dimension, but here one lacks elements of reflection to analyse this beyond of reality, not because we lack a base but because of this end of reality, this going beyond, exceeding of reality. But that's something else that we did talk about a little the other day and we could discuss at length; it's something other than the excess of Bataille where there is still a positive excess, where there is a political resolution almost, with the accursed share of this excess, where therefore there is still the possibility to restabilize, symbolically though, thanks to transgression, something... Whereas here we have simply passed into a sort of pure positivity, a pure virtuality...

Where there are no longer any limits?

J.B.: Yes, exactly, and then we no longer have limits at our disposal, we no longer know where the limits are, we have gone beyond them, we have lost sight of them, it's, well, the quote I use often is that of Cannetti, perhaps you have come across it in the texts, where he says that it is as if humanity has crossed, without realising it, a certain blind spot beyond which nothing is true or false – we no longer know where the limits are, etc. and it's true that beyond limits... it's what produces meaning, a finality, a sense of limits, etc. beyond which phenomena become what I call extreme, extreme phenomena, that is to say that they are beyond terminism/nominalism [*exterministe*],[4] beyond their end, and at this moment they are uncontrollable, in a word, indeterminate, they are interminable. In fact they simply take the form of the catastrophe at this moment. Whereas before we were in the crisis of reality, the crisis of efficiency [*efficacité*], the crisis of values and all that, now we are in a stage of catastrophe in its literal sense, in other words it's not exactly an apocalypse but a form of catastrophe and we don't really have the conceptual and analytical principles to confront it... because all our thinking is itself formed in negativity, in criticism, in traditional analysis, which is situated between a cause and an effect, an origin and an end, [*laughs*] but here I think that there has been a sort of collapse really...



notes

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1 An edited version of this interview appeared as "La Mécanicité Transfinitive," *Stone Soup* 2 (1996): 64-68.

2 In transcribing and translating this oral interview I have remained as close as possible to the original conversational French. [Translator's note.]

3 In French *en jeu* refers both to *in play*, in the sense of boundary (the ball is still *in play*), and *at stake* (*être en jeu*, to be at stake). [Translator's note.]

4 This appears to be a neologism resulting from the conflation of the French nouns *extermination* and *terministe*. A terminist is described in the *New Shorter Oxford English Dictionary* (1993) as "an adherent of terminism," which is defined, in the context of theology, as "The doctrine that God has appointed a definite term or limit in the life of each individual, after which the opportunity for salvation is lost."

Terminism, in relation to philosophy, is equated with nominalism: "The doctrine that universals or abstract concepts are mere names without any corresponding reality." [Translator's note.]

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